International Women's Day Hackathon 2026

Dates: 10th – 11th March 2026.

Duration: 2 days

Location: QMUL basement + Seminar Room + Side Rooms in Maths Building.
Audience: Undergrad + MSc.

Theme: *Mathematics & Computing for Real-World Problems.*
Format: Team-based, beginner-friendly, collaborative.

Goals of this Hackathon are to:

1. Encourage **women and underrepresented groups** in STEM to explore applied, creative problem-solving for real-world problems of their choice.
2. Introduce them to real world research problems and gain experience researching in a collaborative team, brainstorming their own solutions and presenting their answers in front of other like-minded individuals.
3. Introduce **"vibe coding"**: learning how to think, prototype, and iterate using modern tooling (VS Code, Python, notebooks, GitHub, AI copilots)
4. Create a **safe, inclusive, non-competitive** hackathon environment (learning-first, not just winning)

DAY 1 TIMELINE – Intro, Teams and Hack

Time	Session
9:00 AM	Arrival and Team Formation *(SMS Basement)*
9.30AM to 10:25AM	Talk Title: *"Collaborating with others using Git"* *(Seminar Room MB-503)*
10.30AM to 11:25AM	Talk Title: *"Intro to Vibe Coding"* *(Seminar Room MB-503)*
11:30 AM	Break
12 AM to 1 PM	Talk Title: *"Python for Absolute Beginners"* *(Seminar Room MB-503)* *Optional Talk for Beginners* OR Hacking Start *(SMS Basement)*
1:00 PM	Lunch (provided) *(SMS Basement)*
2 PM to 5 PM	First Hacking Session *(SMS Basement)*
5:00 PM	Focused Build Time + Snacks *(Optional in SMS Basement)*

DAY 2 TIMELINE - Hack, Build & Present

Time	Session
9:00 AM	Arrival and Debrief of the Day *(SMS Basement)*
9.30AM to 12.00AM	Second Hacking Session *(SMS Basement)*
11.00AM to 12.00PM	Talk Title: TBC *(Seminar Room MB-503)*
12.00AM to 1.00PM	(Advised) Presentation Prep Time *(SMS Basement)*
1:00 PM	Lunch (provided) *(SMS Basement)*
2 PM to 2.15 PM	Presentations Debrief *(Seminar Room MB-503)*
2.30PM to 4.30PM	**<u>Team Presentations</u>** *(Seminar Room MB-503)* Each team must prepare a 7min presentation + 3min for questions
4:45 PM	Award Announcements & Final Remarks *(Seminar Room MB-503)*

Hackathon Presentation Requirements and Evaluation Criteria

Project Submission Requirements

Each team will work on a project during the hackathon and present their results at the end of the event.

Presentation Format

Each team will deliver a **10-minute presentation**, consisting of:

- **7 minutes presentation**
- **3 minutes Q&A with judges**

The presentation should focus on **the problem, the reasoning process, and the insights obtained**, rather than on the technical details of the code.

Participants are encouraged to present their work clearly and concisely so that **students from different disciplines can understand the project**.

What Your Presentation Should Include

Teams should structure their presentation around the following elements.

Note that this is a guide to how to structure your presentation, not a requirement. Please use your own judgement on how you want to present your results.

1. Problem Description

- What problem are you trying to solve?
- Why is this problem interesting or important?
- What motivated your project idea?

2. Approach and Methodology

- How did you attempt to solve the problem?
- What tools, models, algorithms, or ideas did you use?
- What challenges did you encounter during the process?

Participants do **not need to present detailed code but** should clearly explain their **methods and reasoning**.

3. Results and Findings

- What did your analysis or project reveal?
- Did your method work as expected?
- What insights or discoveries did you make?

4. Prototype or Demonstration (Optional but Encouraged)

If relevant, teams may present:

- A prototype application
- A simple interface or visualization
- A mathematical or computational demonstration
- An interactive notebook or model

The goal is to **show what you built and how it works**.

5. Conclusions and Future Ideas

- What did you learn from the project?
- How could the idea be improved with more time?
- Are there interesting future extensions?

Code Submission

All teams must provide a link to their own repository.

The code submission may include:

- Jupyter notebooks
- Python scripts
- Data analysis code

- Prototype applications
- Documentation or README files

The code **will not be evaluated based on complexity**, but it will serve as a record of the work completed during the hackathon.

Judging Criteria

Projects will be evaluated based on the following criteria:

1. Clarity and Quality of Presentation

- Is the problem clearly explained?
- Is the project understandable to a general STEM audience?
- Is the presentation well-structured and engaging?

2. Analytical Thinking

- Does the team demonstrate thoughtful reasoning and analysis?
- Are the methods appropriate for the problem?
- Do the results follow logically from the approach?

3. Creativity and Innovation

- Is the idea original or interesting?
- Did the team explore creative approaches or new perspectives?

4. Implementation and Execution

- Did the team successfully implement their idea?
- Does the project demonstrate working code, models, or prototypes?

5. Impact and Potential

- Could the idea be extended further?
- Does the project show potential for real-world application?